



1054

Dazzling explosion

Astronomers in China observed an exploding star, or supernova, that remained visible for two years in the constellation Taurus. It left behind a cloud of debris now called the Crab Nebula.

Also on this day

1187 Muslim forces regained control of Jerusalem by defeating the Christian Crusader army at the Battle of Hattin in the Middle East.

1959 Ecuador made the Galápagos Islands its first national park 100 years after the publication of Charles Darwin's book *On the Origin of Species*, which was partly inspired by his visit to the islands.

1997 The *Sojourner* rover landed on Mars and spent 83 days exploring the Red Planet.

July

4

Record rainfall

1956

The world record for the largest amount of rain to fall in a single minute was recorded in Unionville, Maryland, USA. During a storm that flooded homes, flattened crops, and disrupted telephone lines, 31.2 mm (1.23 in) of rain fell in the space of 60 seconds.



Born this day

1868 Henrietta Swan Leavitt, US astronomer. She discovered a way to measure the distance between Earth and various galaxies.

1776

Independence Day

After years of revolutionary war, 13 British colonies in North America adopted the Declaration of Independence, a document that announced their separation from Great Britain and named them the United States of America.

